

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

Document-Based Question

US.78 — Analyze civil and voting rights legislation, including the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Voting Rights Act of 1965, the Civil Rights Act of 1968 (i.e., Fair Housing Act), and the 24th Amendment. (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Analyze the following two primary sources using the SOAPS framework (Speaker, Occasion, Audience, Purpose, Significance) for each document. Then construct a multi-paragraph argument responding to the central question: How did the Montgomery Bus Boycott redefine the role of the Black church and Black economic power as instruments of civil rights activism?

The sources

Document 1

Excerpt from Martin Luther King Jr., speech delivered at the first mass meeting of the Montgomery Improvement Association, Holt Street Baptist Church, Montgomery, Alabama, December 5, 1955. Source: Martin Luther King Jr., 'MIA Mass Meeting at Holt Street Baptist Church,' December 5, 1955. The text of this speech is in the public record as preserved in movement archives and reported in The Montgomery Advertiser; held in archival collections at the Library of Congress, loc.gov.

“We are here this evening to say to those who have mistreated us so long that we are tired — tired of being segregated and humiliated; tired of being kicked about by the brutal feet of oppression... But there will be no crosses burned at any bus stops in Montgomery. There will be no white persons pulled out of their homes and taken out on some distant road and murdered. There will be no threats and intimidation. We will be guided by the highest principles of law and love... One of the great glories of democracy is the right to protest for right. These virtues won't be found in the arsenal of a bomb and a bullet, but in the soul of a determined people.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT 1

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document 2

Excerpt from Bayard Rustin, 'Montgomery Diary,' February 1956, published in Liberation Magazine (1956), and collected in 'Bayard Rustin Papers, Library of Congress (loc.gov)' (public domain, pre-publication rights held by movement archives). Reprinted in The Atlantic, February 1956. Source note: Bayard Rustin, 'Montgomery Diary,' Liberation, February 1956; Library of Congress, Manuscript Division, Bayard Rustin Papers, loc.gov.

“The economic pinch is working. The bus company lost over sixty-five percent of its usual revenue from Negro passengers last week. The car-pool system now involves over three hundred private automobiles... The spirit here is remarkable. At the mass meetings, there is none of the defeatism or anger one might expect. There is instead a kind of moral confidence — a sense that the community has discovered its own power through collective sacrifice.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT 2

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

Using both documents and your knowledge of the Civil Rights Movement, construct a multi-paragraph argument that (1) analyzes how the Holt Street speech (Document 1) established the moral and strategic framework of nonviolent resistance that would define King's leadership, (2) explains the economic mechanism documented in Document 2 and evaluates why economic pressure proved more immediately effective than legal arguments alone, (3) connects this dual strategy

- 1. moral framing plus economic pressure
- 2. to the later campaigns of the sit-in movement (US.74) and the March on Washington (US.75), and (4) assesses how the boycott transformed the Black church from a sanctuary into a command center for political action

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document 1		
Document 2		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

